Japanese-American Internment — EO 9066 & Korematsu v. US

Executive Order 9066 (Feb. 19, 1942) & Korematsu v. United States, 323 U.S. 214 (1944)

Source: U.S. National Archives, archives.gov/milestone-documents/executive-order-9066; Oyez, oyez.org/cases/1940-1955/323us214.

Roosevelt's Executive Order 9066, issued ten weeks after Pearl Harbor, authorized the military to designate 'exclusion zones' from which any persons could be removed. The army used it to forcibly relocate about 120,000 Japanese Americans — two-thirds U.S. citizens — to internment camps for the duration of the war. In Korematsu (1944), a 6-3 Supreme Court upheld the relocation as a wartime measure. Justice Murphy's dissent named the order what it was: 'the ugly abyss of racism.' Congress formally apologized in 1988 and paid reparations to surviving internees.

Connect: Korematsu's 'wartime necessity' argument echoes Lincoln's suspension of habeas corpus (Class 22) and the WWI Espionage Act (Class 38). What's the pattern of civil liberties in wartime?

Key Passages

EO 9066

> I hereby authorize and direct the Secretary of War, and the Military Commanders whom he may from time to time designate … to prescribe military areas in such places and of such extent as he or the appropriate Military Commander may determine, from which any or all persons may be excluded.

Korematsu — Justice Black, for the majority

> We uphold the exclusion order as of the time it was made and when the petitioner violated it. … Korematsu was not excluded from the Military Area because of hostility to him or his race. He was excluded because we are at war with the Japanese Empire.

Korematsu — Justice Murphy, dissenting

> This exclusion of 'all persons of Japanese ancestry, both alien and non-alien,' from the Pacific Coast area on a plea of military necessity in the absence of martial law ought not to be approved. Such exclusion goes over 'the very brink of constitutional power' and falls into the ugly abyss of racism.

Korematsu — Justice Jackson, dissenting

> A military order, however unconstitutional, is not apt to last longer than the military emergency. … But once a judicial opinion rationalizes such an order to show that it conforms to the Constitution, or rather rationalizes the Constitution to show that the Constitution sanctions such an order, the Court for all time has validated the principle of racial discrimination.

HIPP Analysis

Complete each row using evidence from the passages and your background knowledge.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. HIPP — internment documents: Identify TWO different audiences for EO 9066 and explain how the wording serves each.

2. Why did the Court — including liberal justices — uphold internment in 1944?

3. Compare Korematsu (1944) with the Civil Liberties Act (1988). What changed?